secretary Chandra Shekhar (C. S.) Jha noted in Washington, India had questions about whether there would be a return to Stalinism under Soviet Communist Party general secretary Leonid Brezhnev that might lead to a Sino-Soviet rapprochement.[62]

Given the preference for diversifying dependence in order to create space for India, Gandhi tried not to pick fights with either of the country's major benefactors.[63] The day after she was elected Gandhi told Bowles that she wanted to clear up the "gross misunderstanding" that she "leaned towards the USSR." She said she "understood the importance of US assistance, and was profoundly grateful for what [the US] had done."[64] Gandhi also wrote to Johnson, asking for full resumption of economic assistance.[65]

In the lead-up to Gandhi's visit to Washington in spring 1966, her principal secretary Parmeshwar Narayan (P. N.) Haksar told her that the US and India needed to get back to "a stable footing."[66] Before her trip, Komer approvingly credited her government for the lack of Indian press allegations about US pressure tactics.[67] Before and after the visit, Gandhi was careful not to make critical statements about Vietnam.[68] During that trip, she told Johnson that India wanted a "good working partnership" with the US.[69] And after she returned to India, Gandhi and the food minister publicly defended US assistance.[70]

While Gandhi made commitments when she was in the US, there were limits to the concessions she could make. She recognized that development was an important component of national security but knew that a certain level of defense expenditure was necessary.[71] There were political costs to appearing weak on this front. The critical reason for the spending, however, was the dual-front threat. While the Johnson administration was more concerned about India's internal vulnerabilities, Delhi had to prepare for the external challenge too—especially given the questionable reliability of the superpowers.

Thus Asoka Mehta, the planning minister, frankly told Rusk that "As long as [the] need to defend against China remains, India will not be able to reduce [the] level of its defense expenditures very much … If there should be some reduction in Pak defense outlay, India would be willing to match it. Such Indian reduction could not however be 'mixed up' with [the] need for defense against [the] Chinese."[72] Beyond the traditional threat, Beijing's